

The Complete Financial Guide for Young Couples

right, I don't agree with that." Whatever rule I established, he wanted to stretch it. He would stretch it until he reached my boundaries, and then he would back off.

But that day in California, he said something that made all the grief we had endured worthwhile. He said, "Dad, I never told you how much I appreciate what you've done for me. You established discipline in my life that I don't see in most of the other guys I'm around. They cry and they complain and then they wash out because they've never learned to discipline themselves." It was worth all the years of struggling to see the end results in his life. It was worse on me than it was on him, though he probably would not agree with that at all.

As I said earlier, a general guide in budgeting for your children is very simple. The first part of their income should go to God.

The question is often asked, "Should I force my children to tithe?" I personally would not. At ages 1-10, I would encourage them and tell them to do it, because you're developing the principles in their lives. At 11-16, it should be their choice, because you need to find out whether they "believe" what you've been teaching them.

About 25 percent of their earnings should be put into a savings account for short-term use. The next 25 percent should be saved for long-term needs, and about 40 percent should be theirs to spend according to an approved budget.

By the way, I encourage parents not to just drop these principles on their kids. The first step is to put them into your own life and then start sharing them with your children.

I had a young woman call me one time after a seminar. She said, "You have ruined my life."

"How have I ruined your life?" I asked. At that seminar I had been talking about paying for college education, and I shared with the group what we do with our children. We pay half and they pay half.

She said, "You've ruined my life. I came home on spring break from college, and my dad said, 'You can't go back until you earn half of your tuition.'"